officers see themselves as guardians of the legacy of the great Burmese conquering kings, and that their nationalistic duty is to perpetuate this historic vision of an expansionist centre subduing competing kingdoms and other minority peoples. This model of political organization, they argue, has been compounded by the motivation of all post-independence Burman rulers (civilian and military) to restore Burmese prestige and international reputation, and has led most Burmans to still be bound by traditional Burmese social hierarchical thinking. By contrast, these informants argued, Kachin social ideals are far more egalitarian. The Kachin civil society and non-state leaders interviewed co-opt the historic, documented Kachin distinction between *gumlao* (egalitarian-democratic-republican) ideals and *gumsa* (feudal hierarchy with ranked lineages and hereditary privilege) practice (Leach 1970 [1954]).

This is a fascinating narrative for contemporary Kachin leaders and KIO representatives to articulate. The CPB long sought to unify opposition to the Ne Win government along non-ethnic lines, which brought out a heated debate in all groups on the role of ethnicity and ethno-nationalism (Lintner 1990; Smith 1991). The KIO/A gave little support to the CPB's political class analysis and their all-Burman leadership, highlighting that self-determination and addressing Burman chauvinism were their central priorities. The appeal of this sort of narrative, though, as a tool for nationalistic political legitimation and mobilization is obvious, as it suggests that the visible clash of identities is the epiphenomenon of a deeper ideological clash, where ideology is understood as a (universal) process through which human actors articulate their actions and beliefs — making sense of the world around them and how to intervene in it. This narrative lays claim to a fundamental ideological difference between 'Kachin' and 'Burman', and there is clearly some support for such a notion. As one foreign consultant noted, there is a surprising level of symbolic sympathy for the armed groups across the country, particularly the KIO/A, even from those who are critical of their leadership and rent-seeking, and disavow the use of violence. This narrative effectively argues that even if Kachin and KIO/A leadership show some authoritarian and elite rent-seeking behaviour, they in fact remain closer to their people than the Tatmadaw or Burman elite, in both practice and in principle.

It would be unwise to suggest there is only one ideological process of identification (*gumlao* vs *gumsa*) in the Kachin conflict. That would imply yet another homogenizing narrative substituting 'ethnic identity'